Afterword to the Anniversary Edition

SINCE *SAPIENS* WAS PUBLISHED in 2014, *Homo sapiens* has been quite busy. Archeologists and geneticists have continued to shed new light on our past, revealing, for example, the existence of entire human species like *Homo naledi*[1] and *Homo luzonensis*[2] that we didn't know about in 2014. Meanwhile, the pace of the global ecological crisis has intensified. Over the last ten years, 495 plant and animal species have been officially declared extinct,[3] and this is probably only a small fraction of the true number of species lost.[4] Human civilization itself is increasingly at risk from climate change. Around 20 per cent of all carbon emitted by the industrial burning of fossil fuels has entered the atmosphere only after I wrote *Sapiens*.[5] And if anyone had any lingering doubts that we humans are an integral part of the ecological system, the COVID-19 pandemic reminded us that we are animals, and that our species cannot isolate itself from the rest of the organic world.

Unfortunately, instead of uniting in the face of global threats like pandemics and climate change, since 2014 international tensions have increased dramatically. When I wrote in *Sapiens* about the relative decline in international violence, I mused that "this situation might of course change in the future and, with hindsight, the world of today [2014] might seem incredibly naïve." I added that "It is sobering to realise how often our view of the past is distorted by events of the last few years. If this chapter had been written in 1945 or 1962, it would probably have been much more glum. Since it was written in 2014, it takes a relatively buoyant approach to modern history. To satisfy both optimists and pessimists, we may conclude by saying that we are on the threshold of both heaven and hell, moving nervously between the gateway of the one and the anteroom of the other. History has still not decided where we will end up, and a string of coincidences might yet send us rolling in either direction."